



MEDALS GALORE AND RECORDS SHATTERED

Maharashtra **cruised to the top** of the medals table, but it was Bihar, capitalising on home turf, that delivered the most unexpected performance.

Santadeep Dey

santadeep.dey@thehindu.co.in

Maharashtra has, time and again, managed to convince that its on-field prowess isn't a sporting fluke. The seventh edition of the Khelo India Youth Games (KIYG) in Bihar attested to this, as Maharashtra's Under-18 athletes (**above**) completed a hat-trick of team championships in the multi-discipline event.

The State not only accounted for close to 17 per cent of the medals on offer, but also ensured there was daylight between its tally and that of second-placed Haryana. Maharashtra's players won 158 medals (58 gold, 47 silver, and 53 bronze), while the runner-up bagged 117 (39 gold, 27 silver, and 51 bronze). Rajasthan finished third with 60 medals (24 gold, 12 silver, and 24 bronze).

Maharashtra won gold medals in 14 sports, with a majority of them coming from athletics (10), swimming (seven), gymnastics (seven), archery (six), and weightlifting (five).

According to a statement from the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports, most of Maharashtra's standout performers — especially

the archers and weightlifters — already train at Khelo India centres or the National Centres of Excellence (NCoEs) of the Sports Authority of India (SAI) in Aurangabad, Patiala, and Sonapat.

SAI's talent development team also deserves a hat tip for identifying and nurturing 186 of the 5,071 athletes — 50 per cent of them girls — who participated in these Games.

Meanwhile, Bihar, enjoying the privilege of competing in its backyard, sprang the biggest surprise, significantly improving its rank to 15th after finishing 21st in the previous KIYG in Tamil Nadu. It registered seven gold, 11 silver, and 18 bronze medals.

The host recorded a growth of 620 per cent over its showing in